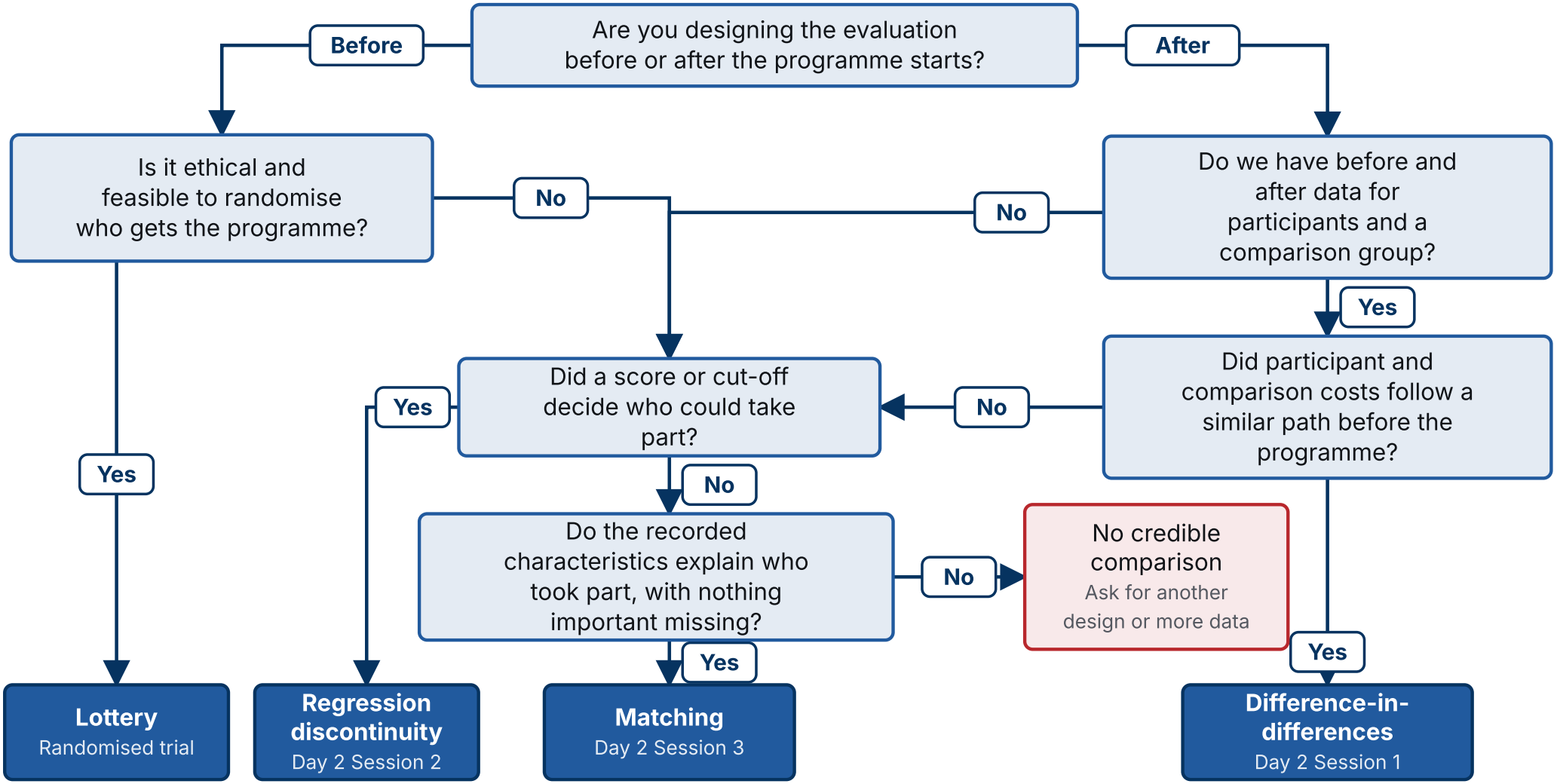
Which method fits? A decision tree for four impact evaluation methods

Start at the top and answer each question for the evaluation you are reading or commissioning. GreenWaste training, Module 2, October 2026.



Lottery (randomised trial)	Groups were assigned by chance. Ask how the draw was done and who dropped out.
Difference-in-differences	Compares the change in participants with the change in a comparison group. Ask whether earlier measurements show similar paths.

Regression discontinuity	Compares businesses just either side of the cut-off. It describes businesses near the cut-off. Ask whether the result holds in a wider window.
Matching	Compares participants with similar non-participants. Ask what was not measured and how close the matches are.
No credible comparison yet	Ask for another design or more data. Until then, read any difference as descriptive, not as the effect of the programme.

The tree covers the four methods taught in this module. Other designs exist; the questions point to the assumption each method rests on, not to a guarantee that the method was done well. Print this page (landscape) to save it as a PDF.